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Teaching under opportunism: The predicament of academic tutors in China

Dongdong Pan and Yisu Zhou
Faculty of Education, University of Macau, China

Abstract

Academic tutoring as a supplementary form of education has quickly spread across China. Tutoring has attracted young college-educated practitioners and has become a highly organized industry. The industry is fast-churning and opportunistic. This article examines the nature of tutors' work using the qualitative data of 31 tutors and their managers in Beijing. Characteristics of tutoring are typical of precarious service labor with irregular work schedules, blurred work–life boundaries, and artificial emotional labor. However, we also found that tutors' work was constrained by their invisible neighbor, schoolteachers, in a linked professional ecology. Tutors have limited jurisdiction over daily tasks and perform reactionary teaching based on school subjects. This lack of control has allowed the industry to rationalize their work, making tutors disposable. Our research offers new insights into the linked professions of tutors and schoolteachers. It enriches the concept of precarious and opportunistic labor practices from the sociology of professions perspective.

Keywords

Linked ecology, precarious labor, professional practice, teaching profession

Introduction

Over the past four decades, private supplementary tutoring has circulated across China at an astounding rate. This global phenomenon demonstrates fast growth in one of the largest consumer markets in the world (Bray and Kobakhidze, 2014). One of its submarkets, the K-12 tutoring sector, has grown from RMB 115 billion in 2010 to 560 billion in market capitalization just 8 years later (Lin, 2022: 2). The industry's practitioners comprise a large and heterogeneous group of academic tutors. This group was estimated to include 7.5–8 million people in 2016 (Chinese Society of Education (CSE), 2016).

Corresponding author:
Yisu Zhou, Faculty of Education, University of Macau, E33-3022, FED, Avenida da Universidade, Taipa, Macau, China.
Email: zhouyisu@um.edu.mo

The supplemental education industry (SEI) is commonly referred to as private tutoring or the shadow education market (Bray and Kwo, 2014).[1] Early tutors of the SEI were opportunistic and disgruntled public sector teachers who sought supplementary income outside their day jobs. Since 2010, the moonlighting scene has matured into large, organized, and financially sophisticated corporations. The SEI is fueled by strong consumer desire, ambiguous state regulations, and globalized financial interests (Lin, 2022). It is also imbued with fierce competition among commercial organizations. Apart from the common concern regarding how the SEI shapes students and parents, this study examines the working conditions and experiences of tutors to understand the nature of their situation in greater detail.

An empirical phenomenon piqued our interest and resulted in our study of this topic. Despite popularity among young job seekers with a college degree and industry analysts' optimistic view (e.g. Deloitte, 2016), the SEI is clouded by terms, such as being a 'young people's game', 'dead-end job', or 'high-attribution occupation', in online job search forums. Job data suggest that tutoring is a fast-churning profession primarily comprised young practitioners (CITIC Securities, 2020). Nationwide statistics indicate that 59% of tutors are below the age of 30, according to a report from the Beijing Normal University (Research Center for Future Education, 2020: 76). The same report depicts a high labor shortage within the SEI; simultaneously, however, there is an increased inflow of recruits (Research Center for Future Education, 2020: 73). The explanation behind this seemingly self-contradictory phenomenon is not immediately apparent.

There are several possible explanations for the tutors' predicament regarding their work scenario. One answer points us to the precarious nature of many professions (Kalleberg, 2018; Standing, 2011). Kalleberg (2018) characterizes precarious work as (1) insecure and uncertain, (2) providing limited economic and social benefits, and (3) having limited statutory entitlements (p. 15). Precarious work emerges as the consequence of neoliberal economic reforms, which demand more relaxed labor regulations and flexible labor forces. The Chinese labor market is moving toward flexibility (Zhou, 2013), hence the explanation.

Yet tutoring in China only partially fits with this template. With the SEI becoming more institutionalized after 2010 (Lin, 2022), the labor arrangements of tutoring seem to converge with other occupations. Major supplemental education organizations (SEOs) are listed on international stock exchanges. The capital market creates another layer of labor practice compliance. Furthermore, tutoring is one of the occupations, which does not discriminate against educational background. Comparatively speaking, salaries can be even higher among new college graduates (CITIC Securities, 2020: 34). This evidence suggests that precarity alone cannot fully explain tutors' situation.

Another line of research points to the institutional roots of the SEI. Lin (2022) characterizes the emergence of the industry in China as 'fruits of opportunism'. Its development can be attributed to a dual ambiguity that is contingent upon China's social transformation (Lin, 2022: 22). SEOs are the poster child of ambiguous ownership and marketability. SEOs thus grew out of the interstitial space between the state and informal economies. The complexity of their origins formed a unique, sometimes even contradictory, institutional logic that is well-recognized by organizational sociologists (i.e. Thornton et al., 2012). The organizational field of SEI created incentives for the organizations within to engage in opportunistic practices by 'taking advantage of circumstances and other social actors with little regard for principles, consequences, or

long-term planning' (Lin, 2022: 27). Our findings are consistent with the notion that labor practices in the SEI indeed resemble such opportunistic characteristics.

However, while institutional analysis has provided insight into the inner workings of the SEI, the focus has not been on frontline practitioners. To understand the predicament tutors face, research must examine their professional work and the evolving professional ecology. As coined in the literature on professions, tutoring can be viewed as a 'turnover profession' (Abbott, 2001: 274). Tutoring jobs expand at a fast pace, populating most Chinese cities. However, they neither have a reproduction body nor represent a stable population of workers. Although they are part of the teaching profession[2] (e.g. Cohen, 2011), tutors occupy the periphery of the professional ecology. The linked ecology thesis (Abbott, 2016: 36–38) stipulates that a specific location and relationship with other professions are key to understanding the process we call professionalization. It is this process that formulates the parameters that constrain tutors' work. In the Chinese context, the teaching profession is arbitrated mainly by the state, where content and proficiency levels are determined at a government level. As such, the teaching profession has become dualized into the core and periphery. Schoolteachers are located at the center. They enjoy stability and relatively higher autonomy – tutors who work at the periphery face more precarious working conditions.

This study uses qualitative methods as the research tools. During 3 months of fieldwork in Beijing, we observed a group of tutors daily to understand their work. We probed into the nature of their work to investigate the predicament of their profession. Our study explores how the SEI reproduces itself based on the life stages of its practitioners. Young practitioners jump in and churn out of the profession at rapid speeds. The tutoring industry provides scarce stabilizing characteristics. Meanwhile, many SEOs are predicated on a large swath of young college graduates. Tutors' instruction is increasingly rationalized via institutional control and monitoring tools. To compete on prices, SEOs deliberately burn out young people with heavy, non-regular workloads and demand them to maintain artificial emotional attachments with clients. Based on our analysis, we offer new insights into the linked professions of tutors and schoolteachers and enrich the concept of precarious and opportunistic labor practices with a perspective from the sociology of professions.

Literature review

Our literature comprises three avenues of research. The literature on precarious work forms the context for understanding the overall labor conditions in China. As discussed in previous sections, the SEI also displayed specific idiosyncratic characteristics, which distinguish tutoring from other teaching professions. Thus, our second strand of literature focuses on opportunistic practices among SEOs. Finally, we discuss how the sociology of professions literature could help bridge the gap between institutional analysis and labor research via the logic of linked professions.

Precarious labor and the teaching profession

Over the past few decades, one of the most widely researched topics in the field of work and occupation is the notion of precarious work; it is seen as closely related to the neoliberal reforms since the late 1970s (Kalleberg, 2009, 2018; Standing, 2011). Precarious

work is an umbrella term. It covers a series of interrelated trends in the labor market. These trends include reducing labor costs, increasing labor deployment flexibility, shedding permanent workers, shifting employment risks to workers, and limiting labor organizations (Kalleberg, 2018). Precarious work includes a variety of labor arrangements. As Lee (2019) stated, precarity is a relational struggle 'over the recognition, regulation, and reproduction of labor' (p. 137).

To use the chronology outlined by Lee (2019), the phenomenon of academic tutoring appeared in China during the high-growth market reform era (1980–2009) and has well extended into the slow-growth period (2010 to the present). Unlike semi-proletarianized factory workers and construction workers who dominated the precarious workforce in previous years (Lee, 2019; Zhang, 2021), tutors work in the service sectors. Their work involves creating knowledge products. This burgeoning profession offers considerably higher wages (Deloitte, 2016), which contrasts with other precious work.

Despite their differences, tutors also share commonalities with lower-tier service professionals. Tutors have limited professional prospects. As a whole, they are highly dependent on SEOs rather than self-reliance in terms of job opportunities. Some common issues about SEOs raised by external observers include abusive labor practices, such as withholding paychecks and offering limited statutory entitlements (CSE, 2016). However, tutors tend to voice their discontent by moving across different SEOs. In a rising industry, job vacancies are ample (CITIC Securities, 2020). This is perhaps why, even though tutors engage in intensive work, they see limited collective bargaining rights like other service sector workers (Lee, 2019). However, there has yet to be mobilization among these young practitioners to advocate for better working conditions.

Another issue previously overlooked by the precarious work literature is the structure of professional ecology. Apart from its direct neoliberal conversion, the Chinese labor market displays certain features one would observe in a coordinated market economy. Political economists termed similar trends as 'dualization' (Thelen, 2014: 13). In these situations, a small segment of core workers typically enjoy high levels of employment protection and high professional status, while an increasing number of peripheral workers are placed under precarious employment (Rueda, 2014; Yoon and Chung, 2016). In some public sectors, the past Chinese *danwei* system was partially retained, even reinvigorated. Workers in these sectors saw job stability and legitimacy increase (Cliff, 2015; Zhang, 2021). The teaching profession, which includes teachers and tutors, fits the dualization definition. Both professions serve the same clientele, school-aged children and their parents. However, at the core, public schoolteachers enjoy a stable working environment with improving compensation (Ye et al., 2019) as the Chinese government has vigorously invested in the professionalization of the schoolteacher workforce in recent decades (Liao and Zhou, 2020).

The peripheral area, including tutors, is rapidly growing and changing. The tutoring profession was almost non-existent four decades ago. However, there were 7–8.5 million tutors nationwide in 2016 by an estimation (CSE, 2016) compared to 11.87 schoolteachers (Ministry of Education, 2017). Lower entry requirements, higher incomes, and opportunism due to a lack of government regulation have led to the rapid growth of tutors in China (Bray and Kwo, 2014; Bray and Lykins, 2012). Tutors' salary is considerably higher, but the job is less protected. Compensation levels also vary significantly.

The highest-paid tutors earn ten times more than their lowest-paid peers in the same group (CITIC Securities, 2020). The labor market is thus shaped by the intertwined dynamics of precarization and dualization (Zhang, 2021).

Opportunistic industry

Besides broad labor conditions, the tutoring industry also uniquely affects tutors' work conditions. The SEI's rise in China represents what Lin (2022) defined as 'opportunist-led changes under ambiguity' (p. 34). The SEI consists of a large group of homogeneous organizations. The state's reconfiguration of the education sector gave rise to soaring demand for supplemental education (Howlett, 2021; Kipnis, 2011). Yet, this new industry is riddled with ambiguity because the state's governing logic concerns 'not what organizations are but what they are not' (Lin, 2022: 27). Consequently, few formalized rules and regulations have existed for the SEI during most of its existence.

Opportunists took several steps to carve out a unique industry under these conditions. First, according to Lin (2022), they pushed out state actors through competition, thus transforming the organizational field (p. 36). With an absence of state actors, state regulations and repertoires gradually lost influence. Second, the success of certain SEOs diffused opportunistic practices across the field. Third, due to this new industry's ambiguity, many opportunistic practices were hidden from the state regulator. Li's (2009) account of the cross-region expansion of a leading SEO illustrates how seemingly unlawful practices flew under the state regulator's radar (p. 331). Regulators did not treat the SEI as a threat to the formal education system and thus never bothered to scrutinize their practices.

Therefore, we can use institutional theorists' view of 'institutional logics' (Thornton et al., 2012: 2–4) to understand these opportunistic practices. Since the SEI was new, and because of the ambiguous nature of this new industry, SEOs' frame of reference became their fellow opportunists. This framing conditioned SEOs' actions and how they viewed themselves. For instance, labor shortages have long been a significant threat to many industries, including teaching. However, many SEOs actively engage in dubious labor practices. Instead of training their workforce, SEOs repeatedly poach talents from each other (Deloitte, 2018). Such patterns are pervasive because there have been no other valid reference points. Furthermore, as our analysis will show, while the state labor law sets an 8-hour workday and a 40-hour maximum week, SEOs exploited the online and virtual nature of emotional labor. This easily allows SEOs to demand more from their tutors. Heavy competition has also led SEOs to reference industry leaders in creating their repertoire.

Academic tutoring as a profession

Tutors from the SEI have also developed a complex relationship with teachers from the traditional school system (e.g. Bray and Kobakhidze, 2015). Researchers characterize this symbolic relationship as both collaborative and competitive. On one hand, the SEI imitates school teaching, which allows tutors to borrow professional legitimacy by emphasizing their similarity with school education. On the other hand, the SEI takes a differentiated strategy to attract more parents and students by emphasizing their advantages over school education (Aurini, 2006; Gupta, 2022). Overall, the SEI has tried to

circumvent the school system to secure its space alongside it rather than attempting to replace the formal institutions of school education (Gupta, online first).

As far as the teaching staff is concerned, there are crossovers and inter-professional mobility between formal education and tutoring. Some schoolteachers may moonlight as tutors, legally or illegally, while seeking a higher income according to the different government regulations of each job (Bray and Lykins, 2012; Kobakhidze, 2018). However, working for SEOs is only the second-best choice for some full-time tutors, many of whom aspired to become schoolteachers later (Trent, 2016). Furthermore, the tutor persona is more diverse than that of schoolteachers. They can play the role of the elder sibling or work as instruments for parental control (Hallsén and Karlsson, 2019) or authoritative exam experts and well-qualified teachers (Yung and Yuan, 2020).

During this process, tutors have imitated, duplicated, and even deepened and extended the work and tasks performed by schoolteachers. The emergence of tutors and their educational entrepreneurialism has changed the connotation of traditional teacher professionalism (Aurini, 2004). Stephen Ball has framed these changes in the teaching profession under a neoliberal lens. He argued that teachers had been framed as educational service providers and entrepreneurs whose chief function is to satisfy the diverse needs of parents and students as consumers and clients (Ball, 2003, 2016).

However, the nature of tutors' work has not been examined from the sociology of professions perspective. Therefore, we do not know how the dynamics between tutors and schoolteachers will affect each other in the context of professionalism and professional jurisdiction. The literature gap further holds us from developing a better understanding of the nature of the teaching profession.

In summary, little research has been found on tutoring from the profession's perspective. Although the literature on precarious labor provides a general context, the SEI only partially fits the template provided. Opportunistic practice forms a secondary lens, yet we found a lack of research from the tutor's perspective. Since previous literature neglected the actual practices of tutors, our analysis provides such an account based on qualitative interviews and analysis informed by the sociology of professions.

Research methods

The data comprise an ethnographic study conducted in Beijing from October 2019 to January 2020. Beijing was chosen as it is home to one of the largest tutoring markets in China. While there are many types of SEOs, this study focuses on tutoring school subjects in elementary and secondary school stages.

Furthermore, we collected data through semi-structured interviews, observations, and document analysis. We interviewed 31 tutors and 3 managers from 15 different SEOs. The interview guideline is consistent with Lareau's (2021) suggestion (e.g. pp. 74–82). Five parents were selected to obtain additional perspectives. Among the 31 interviewed tutors (see Table 4 in Appendix 1 for the information details), 17 were female and 14 were male. Their teaching experience ranged from 1 to 10 years. More than half (54.8%) of our interviewees had less than 3 years of experience. Twenty of 31 were recent college graduates, and the remaining 11 either worked in public schools or other industries. Regarding educational level, 21 tutors had a bachelor's degree, while 10 had a master's degree.

In addition to the interview, we observed the teaching environment of each SEO. The observation allowed us to record interactions among the tutors, parents, and students. We also used field notes to observe classroom teaching. Furthermore, the first author followed a tutor throughout the weekends during peak season for additional observational analysis.

The collected documents comprise both public and private materials. The public materials include related policy documents regarding the government, recruitment, and management regulations of the SEOs. The private materials included course designs, lesson plans, personal work schedules, teaching summaries, and reflections from individual tutors.

After the fieldwork, all the interviews, observations, and documents were transcribed and coded. Regarding interview methods, research has found that individuals' statements are sometimes a poor predictor of their actions (Jerolmack and Khan, 2014). Thus, we strived to match and triangulate data from different sources to ensure consistency between attitudes and actions during the data analysis. All relevant information was obtained confidentially to protect the participants' privacy. Data presented in the next section use pseudonyms.

Findings

Our results are classified under two headings based on the literature review findings: (1) concerning the characteristics of tutoring as a profession and (2) concerning the core of professional logic.

Precarious work

Irregular work schedule. The tutors who participated in our study all worked during the afternoon, evening, weekends, and holidays without any exceptions. As a supplement to school education, private tutoring fills in the time outside regular school schedules. Table 1 illustrates a typical work schedule of a tutor. The schedule is taken from Ms Qian's 2018 work calendar.

Occasionally, Ms Qian has additional job duties in the afternoon. The afternoon hours include more supervision and less instruction. The SEOs provide a space for students whose parents are working. Meanwhile, tutors supervise students completing homework until their parents pick them up. Weekends are an exceptionally busy time for tutors. Most SEOs are open from 08:00 until 20:30. The busiest time of the year is summer (July and August) and winter break (around the Chinese New Year), when students have long segments of free time. Table 2 shows Ms Qian's winter class schedule in 2018. January 27–February 25 was divided into three segments of intensive teaching. During these segments, she worked from 10:15 to 20:30 every day.

Such a work schedule has several characteristics. Unlike schoolteachers, tutors' schedules are almost the opposite in terms of time of day. Our interviewees used words, such as 'unusual', 'unstable', and 'irregular' to characterize their working conditions. Typically, working in the afternoons and evenings indicates that the tutors could not regularly interact with their family and friends. Apart from socializing with

Table 1. Typical work schedule of Ms Qian.

	Mon.	Tue.	Wed.	Thu.	Fri.	Sat.	Sun.
08:00–10:00							
10:15–12:15							Y
13:00–15:30						Y	Y
15:45–17:45						Y	Y
18:30–20:30		Y		Y	Y	Y	Y

Ms Qian teaches politics (social sciences). She has 3 years of experience.

Table 2. Peak season schedule of Ms Qian in 2018.

	No. 1 (Jan. 27–Feb. 2)	No. 2 (Feb. 4–Feb. 10)	No. 3 (Feb. 11–Feb. 13 and Feb. 22–Feb. 25)
08:00–10:00			
10:15–12:15	Y	Y	Y
13:00–15:30	Y	Y	Y
15:45–17:45	Y	Y	Y
18:30–20:30	Y	Y	Y

fellow tutors, they do not have many opportunities to meet other people. One interviewee said,

> I am dissatisfied, and I hope my job will be like that of an average salaryman (*shangbanzu*). I want some regular hours . . . Social activities are important, right? My friends [from the university] are all available on weekends, but I must teach classes. My classes are on Saturday and Sunday every week. I'm the least busy on Tuesday, and although I'll probably be free all day, I will be alone. Who will hang out with me? (Mr Lyu)

An irregular work schedule can impact a tutor's social life, an essential aspect for 20 and 30 year olds. During fieldwork, we discovered that many tutors were single because they had 'no time' (*mei shijian*) for romance or family life. This explanation is corroborated by Ms Yang, who is both a tutor and a manager:

> If tutors stay in this job, rarely would they be able to enter a marriage. They don't have [regular] hours. How could they go on a date? Their working time is the reverse of others. When the [elementary and middle school] students are out of school, and other adults are off from work, the tutors would have to start the classes. When others are off on the weekend, they have to go to work again. These are all opposites.

Apart from the inability to maintain a regular social life, tutors' mental and physical well-being is also a factor to consider. The official tutoring work schedule concludes at 20:30, when evening classes finish. However, opportunistic SEOs required most tutors to stay for student and parent Q&As. Given that the Q&A session is not mandatory, we were puzzled why tutors kept working. We eventually learned that tutors believed this

was a rare one-on-one opportunity to impress their clients to retain them, which will be discussed in the next section.

As a result, only a few tutors would finish their work before 22:00. With winter and summer breaks also come peak seasons. Long teaching hours and extra service work has burned out many tutors, as evident in the descriptions of the participants of this study. Ms Wu compared herself to schoolteachers:

> The work in public schools is less intensive [compared to ours]. At least not this extreme. When I schedule classes during the summer, I will arrange two new backup tutors. They might not have to teach at all, but I will let them get prepared . . . I have four classes a day for seven days straight. Then, I might get a day off before the next segment [of seven days]. [Sometimes], even without rest. My voice would be hoarse after so many days . . . hoarseness, cold . . . All kinds of sick leaves and personal leaves will flood our company. There will be many such things. Everyone is at total capacity at this time. If I don't prepare [for this situation], I am finished.

Blurred work–life boundaries. SEOs take pride in themselves for providing flexible employment. For many outsiders, the intensity of work seems reasonable despite crunch-time seasons. However, SEOs demand tutors to be exemplary service providers. In these scenarios, tutors cannot afford to develop the kind of 'boring' teaching personas common among schoolteachers (Kennedy, 2005: 38–39). Instead, tutors need to actively maintain their relationships with clients. Even more so, they are sometimes pressured to pursue new clients. The cost of this extra work is the invisible personal time involved. In addition, the additional labor requires tutors to engage in emotional labor to guarantee the authenticity of their practices (i.e. Hochschild, 1983).

The bulk of the additional emotional work extends into virtual spaces. Monitored emotional labor is made possible with modern technologies, and the service work has become more onerous in this regard. After a teaching session concludes, tutors will often communicate with the parents – sending course-related materials, activating courseware, and following up with essential learning points using screenshots. These materials are primarily sent and received via the class WeChat groups,[3] usually, including students, parents, and teaching assistants.

During our fieldwork in Beijing, the first author shadowed Ms Shen, a tutor, over several weekends. We found that she would constantly give classroom feedback and answer questions in chat groups when hopping between different teaching locations using the subway. The most demanding clients were never afraid to be intrusive. Some parents initiated discussions about their children's learning issues during non-working hours, including late at night. Therefore, she barely had any idle time between sessions.

Ms Shen was not an exception. Very few of our interviewees maintained a clear work–life boundary. Technology enabled opportunistic SEOs to encourage tutors to engage in this additional work. SEOs treated tutors as a combination of instructional staff, customer service, and salespeople. SEOs mandated close connection with the parents, latching onto students after tutoring hours. Furthermore, the 'always-on' technological features of the SEO working environment encroached on the personal living space of tutors (e.g. Qi, 2020). Figure 1 illustrates this point using a training manual from a leading SEO that depicts the instructions given to all tutors.

Figure 1. An excerpt from the training manual of the Venus Company. Masked cooperate logo. Specific instructions are given on how to engage with parents using chat groups. Translated by the authors.

This blurring of the work–life lines that tutors face contrasted strongly with that of public schoolteachers. Although teacher–parent chat groups are common in formal educational settings, communication is often one-way – from teachers to parents. Parents generally do not disturb teachers during non-working hours, especially not on weekends. The boundaries between the work and life of public schoolteachers are more clearly demarcated. Whereas for tutors, the seemingly more accessible work scenario has a hidden cost of sacrificing personal time unwillingly. No tutor in our study indicated that they could completely break away from work. Ms Feng, who had been a schoolteacher before, told us:

> Our working time is flexible . . . But that does not mean you can relax at home. For example, I only have one class on Monday, but parents will keep sending questions [over messaging apps]. Then, we assign kids homework every day, and they would need feedback . . . On my busiest day, I have about 20 classes. That means the students in these 20 classes will all contact me. 'Ms. Feng, I handed in today's homework, and please help me correct it'. Then, the mother may say, 'Oh, please take a look at my child's work'. Can I ignore them? No way. I used to take a break on weekends when I was a public schoolteacher. When I break, I do nothing. Although my work is very flexible now, I can't take a break today and do nothing. I cannot do that . . . If I were a schoolteacher, parents would not bother me on weekends. They would wait until Monday . . . Really, most parents refrain from asking teachers [over the weekends] . . . I rest on weekends, and so do other teachers. I can go out without my phone. But now, I feel that the phone has grown on me. I must pay attention to group messages at any time. That's my situation.

The type of service work that tutors provide is more than mechanical and routine. Many parents expect tutors to respond to their queries promptly; otherwise, some would not hesitate to complain. Therefore, tutors are typically always engaged in work mode. SEOs rely entirely on tuition fees as their revenue. The revenue, in turn, is reflected in enrollment figures. Every SEO emphasizes respecting clients' demands as a result. Regarding the professional triad of tutoring, compared to SEOs and parents/students, tutors are the weak node. Every tutor we interviewed had a story about demanding parents, like this one shared by Ms Feng:

> There was a parent who demanded a lot from tutors. Her kid left me because the parent didn't like me . . . The parent persistently sent two essays to me daily [for feedback]. Once she sent it to me, I had to read it immediately and give feedback; otherwise, she would keep sending messages, like 'have you not read it, Ms. Feng? I'll send it to you again', 'I sent you a message just now, but you have not responded. I'll send it to you again'. [Showing messages to the interviewer] This is the child's grandmother. She would keep prompting you to revise the child's work. I told her that I was in a class and would do it afterward. Then, she would send another message at the exact time when I got off. 'Have you got out of class, Ms. Feng? Could you please have a look at the essay?' It pissed me off . . . I had only one hour for my lunch break. Grading an essay in one hour?! . . . That parent was not too happy. She said that I was indifferent. She told our staff, 'I sent her my child's homework every day, but she did not respond'.

The notion that tutors must stay online at all times and be accessible via communication tools was confirmed by the interviews we conducted with parents. As a mother and a client of an SEO, Ms Dou believes tutors must promptly respond to parents' messages. Otherwise, the 'attitude is unacceptable', and they may find a different tutor for their children:

> If a tutor ignores my messages for a long time . . . I would immediately ask my child, 'Is she okay? Why did the tutor ignore us? This one is so-so (*yibanban*)! Get another one'. I will demand a change immediately. Such an attitude is unacceptable. (Ms Dou – parent, aged 55)

Limited career perspective and life-stage profession. Tutoring is a young person's profession. According to government statistical data from August 2021 (The People's Government of Beijing Municipality, 2021), more than 90% of tutors in Beijing are aged 35 and below. Seniority has a different connotation among tutors than in other professions; those with 2 years of teaching experience would be called senior professionals. Besides personal reasons for leaving the job, SEOs provide limited stabilizing forces. As demonstrated in the literature and our interview excerpts, tutors' work is intensive and often extends beyond regular contract hours. The work intensity is not simply physical but emotional as well. Most SEOs operate on the logic of 'performance', measured using metrics, such as students' return or conversion rates.[4] As a result, young tutors cannot let any of their clients go. They must invest in every potential client with as much emotional labor as necessary to retain them.

SEOs tend to treat their practitioners based on structural calculations. China's higher education institutions have expanded rapidly since 1999. In 2021, the system graduated a record 8.27 million students – previously 6.08 million in 2011 and just over 1 million

in 2001. However, the job market is nowhere ready to absorb this many college graduates. The SEI is among the few professions that welcome everybody with a college degree. We were repeatedly told that SEOs do not have long-term plans for their tutors. A typical replacement period lasts 2–3 years – that means, every 2–3 years, most SEOs will have a completely different batch of tutors.[5]

Therefore, with a large reserve, a unique coupling has been formed between tutors and SEOs. Tutors have a short shelf life and SEOs treat their workers opportunistically. After using their services, SEOs will find another new, raw, and young batch of tutors. SEOs are keen on their revenue. They achieve survival and development through continuous, round-by-round replacement of senior tutors. SEO managers have also corroborated this scenario. For instance, Ms Yang, a manager at a large SEO, believes a renewal cycle of every 2 years or so has become a default in the industry:

> I don't want to keep a tutor for long. What we need is fresh blood. In fact, after a specific time, senior tutors will burn themselves out. We don't particularly want to keep such people. A two-year cycle is not only a requirement, an idea proposed here by the company, but also fits tutors' needs. I think each side gets what they want. Older tutors definitely will be a little arrogant because of their service time. No wonder the maintenance and other services for students in the later period will drop.

Corporate managers, such as Ms Yang, framed their relationship with tutors as mutually beneficial without mentioning the exploitative nature of the job. Our tutor interviewees did not see things that way. After working in the industry for a while, many realized they would not have a career there. However, the exact time of turnover varies, as Mr Sun told us:

> You can only make some quick bucks for a short period in SEOs. It is not possible to maintain this state for long. 'A short period' does not necessarily mean a few months, a year, or two. It could be four, five, or six years . . . Your body will not sustain this work when it reaches a tipping point.

Another reason the SEI continues to attract willing youth is higher wages, usually higher than schoolteachers.[6] However, schoolteachers are seen to enjoy the kind of security and career prospects that tutors do not have. The career ceiling for tutors is evident. Tutors also face many problems in the structure of their work, such as a lack of welfare benefits, professional belonging, and limited career development opportunities (CSE, 2016). They are also faced with heavy market competition, which teachers are shielded from since they work in public institutions. One tutor told us,

> When the company had a good run, it expanded rapidly. However, it quickly closed down regional centers when it was not doing well. You would feel that it is indeed unlike a regular school. You don't build a school one day and tear it down the next day. (Ms Zhu)

The fear of losing their jobs prompts many tutors to seek alternative career trajectories. The skill path dependence leads them toward securing a spot in public schools:

> Most new tutors earn more. They are quite satisfied. However, gradually over the past two years, you would feel the instability after people leave one after another. To ensure the

> company could sustain itself, they would lay off the tutors deemed 'making a little contribution' . . . Now, I sometimes think about it, especially when I'm too tired . . . Sometimes, I would hold out and think, 'Oh, go back to my hometown and be a schoolteacher . . . I'm sure it is okay, right? You have taught for so many years, and you have some experience. It should not be too bad'. (Mr Kong)

The high concentration of young practitioners, limited job prospects, and higher turnover eventually equate the tutoring profession with other life-stage or turnover professions, such as food-service assistants, private household child-care workers, and short-order cooks. Tutors, as a group, are not comprised the same people over time, unlike most medical doctors who stay in their jobs to make for the actual demography of the profession, for example.

Abbott (2001) offered a stylized definition of occupation consisting of three elements: (1) a particular group of people, (2) a particular type of work, and (3) an organized body or structure other than the workplace itself that is capable of some reproduction. Some occupations may contain all these three attributes, while others may lack one of the three attributes. Accordingly, four types of professions are identified: strong-form professions, quasi-professions, workless professions, and turnover professions. The last category is 'an organizational structure tied to a particular body of work, but no consistent group of people doing that work' (Abbott, 2001: 274). Such professions consist of individuals only at specific points of the life cycle. Ultimately, the job of tutoring fits this description of turnover professions.

Limited jurisdiction

We also analyzed the jurisdiction of the tutors that participated in our study. Jurisdiction is the legitimized professional authority granting professionals exclusive work areas (Abbott, 1988). However, tutors' jurisdiction did not result from open conflicts with schoolteachers. It grew from the gap in services determined by the Chinese state, augmented by strong parental demand to pursue academic excellence (Hizi, 2019; Howlett, 2021; Kipnis, 2011; Yuan, 2021).

In curbing educational desire spurred by meritocratic ideology, the state has repeatedly vowed to fight excessive academic crunching. In 2013, the state issued a mandate to reduce the burden on parents and students – *Ten Regulations to Reduce Academic Burden for Primary School Students*. This rule limits primary school instruction to 6 hours per day. It also requires all school students to be out of school by 15:30. While the boundary separating schools from the outside seems very black and white, 'each jurisdictional event that happens to one profession leads adjacent professions into new openings or new defeats' (Abbott, 2016: 36). However, schoolteachers have exclusive claims on school activities, and strict regulations also confine their reach. The structural limits posed by formal regulation afford parents and children additional time and space, which they seek to fill. The tutors' work can thus be contextualized in an environment where the SEI addresses parental demands.[7]

SEOs have become such a space for bridging schools and homes. They do so in a particular way. It is common for tutors to deliver instructions to students and their parents

Figure 2. A session in the Mercury Company on mathematics. Students sit in the first two rows. Parents sit at the back.

simultaneously, as depicted in Figure 2. According to our observations, SEOs rarely provide any new content vis-à-vis instruction. They are reactionary or supplementary in nature. The classes offered in SEOs are organized in mini-lessons that reflect the official school curriculum. In Table 3, we present two curricula: on the left is a national mathematics textbook for year 1 high school students, while on the right is the manual published by one of the largest SEOs. The teaching and learning strictly followed the prescribed contents. The two curricula aligned perfectly. As we have been repeatedly told, the content taught by an SEO is the distilled version of school curricula. They follow the same structure but punctuate topics that often appear on tests. This close alignment occurs in almost every subject area. One of SEO's research and development activities is to develop short, concise, and practical manuals suited for instruction.

The alignment between the SEO and school curricula reflects tutors' limited jurisdiction. They cannot actively define and control the contents of their work as their schoolteacher counterparts. Due to the structural boundary, tutors cannot take over schoolteachers' work but only pick up what the latter has left.

The weak control for tutors over their work is structural, as Table 3 suggests, and substantial. This lack of control is most evident regarding instruction. As is the case for schoolteachers, the professional knowledge of teaching is primarily embedded in the organizational structure of an SEO. Each SEO gives new tutors intensive training in notes, manuals, and sanctioned procedures to deliver a course. Many of the tutors we

Table 3. Comparing the contents of a textbook and the syllabus of an SEO.

High School Mathematics Textbook Volume 1 contents		Course contents of an SEO
Chapter 1. Sets and Common Logic Terms	1.1 The Concept of Set	1. Sets
	1.2 The Basic Relationship between Sets	
	1.3 Basic Operations on Sets	
	1.4 Sufficient Conditions and Necessary Conditions	
	1.5 Universal Quantifiers and Existential Quantifiers	
Chapter 2. Unary Quadratic Functions, Equations, and Inequalities	2.1 Equality Properties and Inequalities Properties	2. Expansion of the Three Elements of Functions
	2.2 Fundamental Inequalities	3. Synthesis of the Properties of Functions
	2.3 Quadratic Functions and Unary Quadratic Equations, Inequalities	4. Quadratic Functions
Chapter 3. Concepts and Properties of Functions	3.1 The Concept of Function and its Representation	
	3.2 Basic Properties of Functions	
	3.3 Power Functions	
	3.4 The Application of Functions (1)	
Chapter 4. Exponential Functions and Logarithmic Functions	4.1 Exponential	5. Exponential and Exponential Functions in Depth
	4.2 Exponential Functions	6. Logarithm and Logarithmic Functions in Depth
	4.3 Logarithm	7. Midterm Review
	4.4 Logarithmic Functions	8. Functions and Equations
	4.5 The Application of Functions (2)	
Chapter 5. Trigonometric Functions	5.1 Arbitrary Angles and Radians	9. Arbitrary Angle Trigonometric Functions
	5.2 The Concept of Trigonometric Function	
	5.3 Induction Formula	10. Induction Formula, Graphs, and Properties of Trigonometric Functions
	5.4 Graphs and Properties of Trigonometric Functions	
	5.5 Trigonometric Identities Transformations	
	5.6 Function $y = A\sin(\omega x + \phi)$	11. Graphs and Properties of Sinusoidal Functions
	5.7 The Application of Trigonometric Functions	

SEO: supplemental education organizations.

interviewed mentioned this kind of fast-track training (*sucheng*). The training aims to transform the 'novice' tutor (*xiaobai*) to 'look like a serious educator, and then become a qualified product' (Mr Wei). Ms Wu, who is also in charge of tutor training and class arrangement in a large SEO, likened training tutors to 'force-feeding a duck' (*tianya*). The SEOs require tutors to be 'quickly sent to the market'. For tutors, such a detailed 'induction' is organized down to the most basic unit of a course. One large SEO training manual we examined consists of 300 hours of content, from writing lesson plans, drawing stick figures, explaining complex sentence patterns, and communicating with parents.

These prescribed contents resemble a high degree of rationalization in treating teaching as a standard operating procedure. Ms Wang, who has taught in public schools before, told us:

> For instance, they want to standardize the process, pushing it [for some time] now. Our original understanding is that [they want] the teaching goals to be specific and the teaching programs to be fixed. Previously, as long as your teaching process is smooth, whether you follow every sentence in the teaching plan or use one teaching plan for the whole group of more than 100 tutors, [it is fine]. However, I feel it is becoming unrealistic [when they ask us to follow the book strictly]. Since students are different, your language cannot be the same. Yet, managers want all your words exactly what they want students to hear, and they installed 2 to 3 surveillance cameras in each classroom [to monitor instruction]. They will take turns watching your classes. Is your teaching following [prescribed] procedures and language? For a tutor with five to eight years of experience, if she says the wrong word in class, [the manager] will stare at her and say 'NO'.

Furthermore, even with the monitorial system, most tutors we interviewed displayed a level of agency. They offered their clients diagnosis, inference, and treatment as other professionals do (Abbott, 1988). However, they did it by subsuming themselves first to the SEO's prescribed methods and then to the official schoolwork. The tutors we interviewed for this study do not challenge external knowledge. They respect the authority of the school knowledge and provide their interpretation to help clients master it. Tutors are the vassal state to schoolteachers in the grand professional turf war. Many tutors define themselves as providing patchwork to school learning. They tinker, reinforce, and improve on what has been taught during the day.[8] All the tutors we interviewed acknowledged their secondary position. Ms Zhao articulated this:

> Public schoolteachers will emphasize that they are authorities. However, we are not. We simply don't have that much authority.

Students and parents embrace this sense of hierarchical authority. They develop a clear objective by prioritizing schoolwork and treating tutoring work as secondary. One senior tutor, Ms Li, described one of the students she tutored:

> A child could sign up with multiple agencies (*baoban*). Thus, he usually develops a priority. 'This is the work assigned by the schoolteacher', and 'that is the work from the tutor' . . . I don't want to do homework, but no. Homework from schoolteachers must be done, right?

As a result of this priority hierarchy, tutors' practices are limited to a highly contrived and increasingly rationalized work environment. Their professional knowledge system is derived based on schoolwork. Tutors cannot create an apparatus of professionalization since they cannot constitute these tasks into identified jurisdictions. Tutors' professional knowledge is heavily embedded in SEO. Mr You articulated clearly:

> The institution, the platform, has stripped all core competencies . . . Thus, it is easy to lose oneself. You no longer have the ability to think independently and improve your teaching capacity.

Mr You referred to the highly rationalized system consisting of online tutorial videos, pre-produced teaching notes, and other practices. This system varies from SEO to SEO, depending on the organizational principle and the technology each deploys. However, the similarity is striking. Professional teaching is streamlined in manuals (e.g. '100 cases for classroom management') and becomes outcome-oriented as tutors are repeatedly tested.

Our findings suggest that the level of control over work in the tutoring profession is weak compared to the teaching profession. Jurisdictional conflict is first won by schoolteachers, where the knowledge is defined. Second, we see a rational and managerial system among the SEOs, restraining each tutor's professional autonomy.

Conclusion and discussion

The current study provides a sociological analysis of tutoring as a profession. This study achieved several goals. First, we documented the precarious nature of tutors' work in China. The booming SEI does not provide stabilizing forces for its practitioners. Like many other precarious work scenarios, tutors have irregular schedules, blurred work–life boundaries, and are required to engage in artificial emotional labor. Such characteristics reflect broader labor conditions in the service sector in China and opportunistic labor practices unique to the SEI.

These conditions certainly fuel the predicaments that tutors face. Similar to other service professions in China, there is no collective bargaining between tutors and their employers. As a result, the tutors' work is highly rationalized yet contrived in a complex and competitive techno-managerial industry. We report here that such precarious work can be extreme.

Second, we explored tutors' predicaments from a sociology of professions lens. Tutors and schoolteachers form an interesting duo. They are linked not just by the same clientele but also by a deep meritocratic desire from parents and students. The professional lives of tutors are in perpetual flux because of larger labor trends and industry characteristics, and due to the linked nature of the professional ecology between schoolteachers and tutors. Parents export the functions of supervising homework and improving learning to the tutors. Students come to tutors to boost academic performance. However, it is the schoolteacher and the school who control the definition of learning outcomes. Tutors try to distill the elixir of academic performance when they cannot define good performance. The tutors we interviewed in this study typically play a never-ending catch-up game and

cannot gain jurisdictional control over their work situations. Hence, the tutoring occupation essentially becomes a life stage for young college graduates. Many of our interviewees expressed their hope in becoming 'real' teachers in securing a spot in a public school. However, very few succeeded at the time of this study. We see no evidence of how tutors we interviewed can elevate themselves to professional status.

Finally, we extend our research to consider the professionalization discourse. The ideals of the teaching profession have long pinned its hope on the growth of professional knowledge. A teaching professional is believed to mature through acquiring more technical knowledge, obtaining a certain level of education, infusing strong practices inside schools, and improving over time (e.g. Hargreaves and Fullan, 2012). The implicit assumption is that knowledge grows with teaching (Shulman, 1986). However, very few studies examine professional competency in other professions in the same ecology.

Our depiction of tutors shows how an opportunistic industry has exploited them and rendered their professional growth nearly impossible. Our research demonstrates how professional knowledge can be stripped from its professional aspect and embodied in the organization and the commodity, echoing previous predictions (Abbott, 1991). Consequently, tutors must rely on other means to sustain themselves in the ever-changing market. Their professional legitimacy depends on performance and personal ties. On the performance side, the ability to quickly improve students' test scores is a crucial element. On the personal side, tutors rely heavily on emotional labor to retain their clients without the institutional protection and cultural authority from the school.

Thus, tutors' predicament is the result of multiple factors. In particular, the situation we described differs from the outright deregulation of the entire professional spectrum (Thelen, 2014: 11–18). Instead of seeing a direct assault on the teaching profession typically discussed in the neoliberal literature (c.f. Ball, 2003), the professional core witnesses increased collaboration and improved investment by the state (Ye et al., 2019). Based on our interviews and analyses, we suggest that such status is unreachable for tutors, who are on the other end of the teaching spectrum. The professional lives of tutors are dominated by opportunistic industry labor practices. Tutors do not have much control over the tasks they are required to perform.

Nevertheless, we consider it fitting to discuss the two professions together due to their linked ecology. The challenging situation faced by tutors is indicative of that of schoolteachers. In July 2021, *The Guidelines on Further Reducing the Burden of Homework and Off-campus Tutoring for Students Undergoing Compulsory Education*, jointly issued by the Party Central Committee and State Council, dealt a major blow to the booming SEI. Under this policy, most for-profit SEOs had to either transform into non-profit organizations or fold for good. Over a few months, the entire industry, consisting of more than 400,000 SEOs and 10 million employees, has nearly evaporated. The regulation laid out strict articles on the content and time allowed for tutoring.[9]

The regulation will likely impact the professional ecology in the years to come. The new regulation requires public schools to improve their after-school programs to meet the diverse needs of students, such that parents can be assured that their children are in good hands without turning to tutors. The government has demanded that schoolteachers take up some of the tasks that tutors have initially performed. Even with good intentions, this radical move could put teachers' professionalization projects in another peril by

asking them to do more without the promises of new resources. It was premature to assess the effects of the new regulation at the time of this study, although under-investment in public schools is nothing new in China (Yin and Zhu, 2012). Whether the predicament that tutors face is perpetuated can be examined in future research.

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ORCID iD

Yisu Zhou https://orcid.org/0000-0001-9246-9700

Notes

1. According to Lin (2022), the supplemental education industry (SEI) evolved over several stages in China. The timing of the current project coincides with the post-2010 development, where a nationally integrated industry has fully emerged. Our focus is the K-12 segment. Therefore, we excluded tutors from TOEFL/GRE, National Graduate Entrance Examination, and the Spoken English sector from our study. The latter three form other important segments of the SEI.
2. A reviewer asked us to clarify what we mean by the teaching profession. For our purpose, the teaching profession includes those engaged in teaching work and activities in legitimate educational organizations – teachers working in public and private schools, and tutors working in SEOs fit such criteria.
3. WeChat is one of China's most popular instant messaging apps, developed by the Tencent company.
4. Conversion rate (*zhuanhua lyu*) is jargon used in the SEI. It is a key indicator for measuring the rate from which those participants at the trial stage stay on to pay fees for continued instruction. Most supplemental education organizations (SEOs) offer the wholesale of a program (i.e. a semester-long course on math) as well as short-duration courses. SEO's intentions are to have tutors retain as many students as possible.
5. Quotes from Ms Li and Mr Jiang.
6. The income of tutors varies largely between regions and cities. Taking Beijing as an example, even a fresh graduate who has just entered the industry can have an overall monthly income of more than RMB 10,000 yuan (US$1570), according to our field investigation. In comparison, the corresponding teachers' is RMB 5000–7000 yuan (US$785–1099).
7. The account here is simplified. We focused on the professional context while ignoring other structural actors. For a comprehensive account, see Lin's 'two-dimensional ambiguity' theory

on SEI's rise in China (Lin, 2022: 20ff). SEI started as an informal economy and successfully retained its ambiguity on its for-profit nature in the initial stage. SEI is endogenous to Chinese learners' desire for social mobility and better education.

8. Our interviewees suggest that this approach makes both educational and business senses. Curriculum development is very expensive, and most SEOs do not wish to invest in an area that could easily be copied. There is no copyright protection in the tutoring sector. This might be another reason almost every tutoring manual we examined reflected some modification based on existing textbooks.
9. Some would argue this regulation essentially prohibits any for-profit tutoring. We do not disagree with such an assessment, but this is beyond the topic of this current article. Our estimate is that the SEI is heavily wounded but not entirely eliminated. Given the strong demand for academic learning remains, it is possible the SEI will make a comeback. Domestically, the real estate market provided useful lessons (Ding et al., 2017). Internationally, South Korea is another example (Choi and Choi, 2016).

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Author biographies

Dongdong Pan is a Postdoctoral Research Fellow at the Faculty of Education, University of Macau. His current research focuses on the identity and labor process of academic tutors in China.

Yisu Zhou is an associate professor at the University of Macau's Faculty of Education. Zhou is a sociologist. He has researched diverse areas of people and institutions in the educational setting. Zhou's research stems from his lifelong interest in understanding people and places, which he formally developed since his days as a rural schoolteacher after college. Zhou's current project investigates various aspects of the teaching profession.

Appendix 1

Table 4. Background of interviewed tutors.

Name	Degree	Teaching subject(s)	Years of teaching in SEI	Year(s) of teaching in public schools (if any)
Mr He	Master	English	5	NA
Mr Hua	Bachelor	Chinese	9	NA
Mr Jiang	Bachelor	Chinese	2	NA
Mr Jin	Bachelor	Mathematics	3	NA
Mr Kong	Master	Mathematics	3	NA
Mr Lyu	Bachelor	Math, Physics and Chemistry	2	NA
Mr Sun	Bachelor	Mathematics	3	NA
Mr Tao	Master	English	7	NA
Mr Wei (卫)	Master	Chinese	2	NA
Mr Xu	Bachelor	Mathematics	10	1
Mr Yan	Bachelor	Mathematics	7	1
Mr You	Bachelor	Physics	4	NA
Mr Zhang	Bachelor	Chinese	3	NA
Mr Zhou	Bachelor	Physics	3	NA
Ms Cao	Master	English	2	NA
Ms Chen	Master	History	4	NA
Ms Chu	Bachelor	English	6	NA
Ms Feng	Bachelor	Chinese	3	8
Ms Han	Master	English	4	8
Ms Li	Bachelor	Mathematics	8	NA
Ms Qian	Master	Politics	3	NA
Ms Qin	Bachelor	Chinese	2	NA
Ms Shen	Master	Physics	1	NA
Ms Shi	Bachelor	Chinese	5	6
Ms Wang	Bachelor	Chinese	1	4
Ms Wei (魏)	Bachelor	Mathematics	2	NA
Ms Wu	Bachelor	Chinese	3	NA
Ms Yang	Bachelor	English	8	NA
Ms Zhao	Master	Chinese	2	NA
Ms Zheng	Bachelor	Mathematics	5	NA
Ms Zhu	Bachelor	English	4	NA

SEI: supplemental education industry.
All names are pseudonyms.

Résumé
Le soutien scolaire en tant que forme d'enseignement complémentaire connaît une expansion rapide en Chine. Cette activité, qui attire des jeunes diplômés de l'enseignement supérieur, est devenu une industrie très organisée. L'évolution du secteur est rapide et marqué par l'opportunisme. Dans cet article, nous examinons la nature du travail des professeurs particuliers à partir des données qualitatives de 31 professeurs particuliers et de leurs responsables à Pékin. Les caractéristiques du soutien scolaire sont typiques d'un travail de service précaire, avec des horaires de travail irréguliers, des limites floues entre travail et vie privée, et un travail émotionnel artificiel. Cependant, nous avons également constaté que le travail des professeurs particuliers était limité par leur voisin invisible, les enseignants, dans une écologie professionnelle liée. Les professeurs particuliers ont une autorité limitée sur les tâches quotidiennes et dispensent un enseignement réactif basé sur les matières scolaires. Ce manque d'autorité a permis à l'industrie de rationaliser leur travail, rendant les tuteurs remplaçables. Notre recherche offre de nouvelles perspectives sur les professions liées des professeurs particuliers et des enseignants. Elle étoffe le concept de pratiques de travail précaires et opportunistes du point de vue de la sociologie des professions.

Mots-clés
écologie liée, pratique professionnelle, profession d'enseignant, travail précaire

Resumen
Las clases particulares como forma complementaria de educación se ha extendido rápidamente por toda China. Las clases particulares han atraído a jóvenes profesionales con educación universitaria y se ha convertido en una industria altamente organizada. La evolución del sector es rápida y marcada por el oportunismo. Este artículo examina la naturaleza del trabajo de los profesores particulares usando datos cualitativos de 31 profesores particulares y sus gerentes en Beijing. Las características de las clases particulares son típicas del trabajo precario en el sector servicios con horarios de trabajo irregulares, límites borrosos entre trabajo y vida personal y un trabajo emocional artificial. Sin embargo, también hemos hallado que el trabajo de los profesores particulares está limitado por su vecino invisible, los docentes, en una ecología profesional vinculada. Los profesores particulares tienen jurisdicción limitada sobre las tareas diarias y realizan una enseñanza reactiva basada en las materias escolares. Esta falta de autoridad ha permitido al sector racionalizar su trabajo, haciendo desechables a los profesores particulares. Esta investigación proporciona nuevas perspectivas sobre las profesiones vinculadas de los profesores particulares y los docentes. Y enriquece el concepto de prácticas laborales precarias y oportunistas desde la perspectiva de la sociología de las profesiones.

Palabras clave
ecología vinculada, práctica profesional, profesión docente, trabajo precario